

AIRPDF FIELD NOTES / 2026

The quiet PDF reader for every desk.

A feather-light reader for the documents that matter. Built with .NET and Avalonia. Open source, from the first line.

PDFium · Avalonia · .NET 10

A sample document
for the AirPDF test suite

CHAPTER ONE · LESS, BUT BETTER

Reading should feel like nothing at all.

Most PDF apps ask for a login, a cloud account, a subscription, and a slice of your attention before they show you a single page. AirPDF starts with the page.

There is a particular kind of calm that comes from opening a document and simply reading it. No onboarding tour. No sidebar of recommendations. No modal asking whether you would like to try the premium plan.

AirPDF is an attempt to preserve that calm. It renders with PDFium, the same open-source engine behind browsers, so the page in front of you is the page the author intended.

The interface is deliberately small: a rail of thumbnails, a quietly persistent toolbar, and a canvas that gets out of the way. The keyboard does the rest.

Lightweight is not a number on a download page. It is the feeling that the tool has already finished loading before you have decided what to read.

8
PAGES IN THIS NOTE

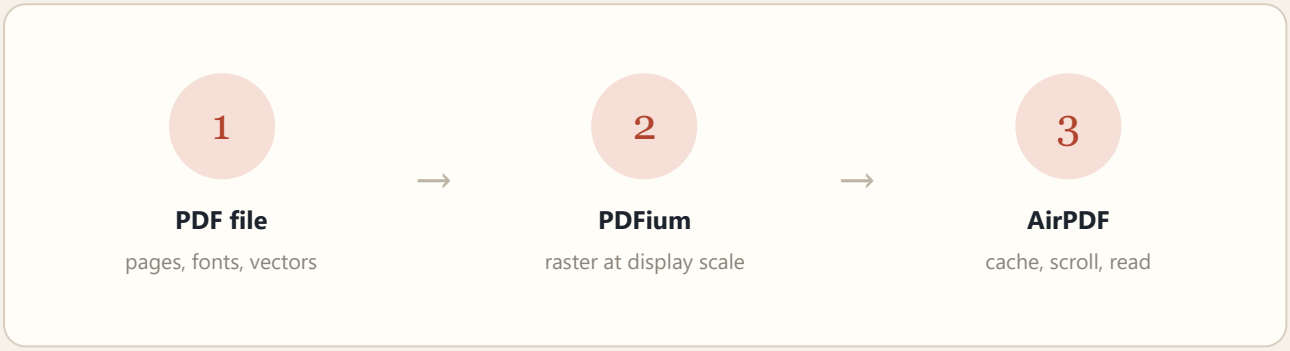
1
KEYBOARD SHORTCUT TO FOCUS

0
ACCOUNTS REQUIRED

CHAPTER TWO · THE ENGINE

Rendering without the weight.

PDFium turns the document into pixels. Skia moves those pixels to the screen. Avalonia gives the whole thing a native window on Windows, macOS, and Linux. Each piece is open source, and each has one job.



WHY THIS STACK

Avalonia compiles the same XAML into a native window on every desktop. .NET gives us one runtime, one build pipeline, and a mature package ecosystem. PDFium keeps rendering predictable across platforms, including the awkward documents that older libraries struggle with.

The result is a reader that opens in under a second on a normal laptop and stays out of the way while you scroll. Text search is handled by PdfPig, which reads the PDF content stream directly and returns match boxes for highlights.

01

Native rendering

Pages are rasterized at the exact display scale, so text stays crisp when you zoom.

02

Virtualized pages

Only the pages near the viewport are decoded. Long documents stay light.

CHAPTER THREE · EVERYWHERE

The same page on every desk.

Windows, macOS, and Linux share the same reader, the same shortcuts, and the same typography. There is no “web version” with a different set of bugs.

PLATFORM	WINDOW	RENDERER	STATUS
Windows 10 / 11	Win32	PDFium	Supported
macOS 13+	AppKit	PDFium	Supported
Linux x64	X11 / Wayland	PDFium	Supported
Linux arm64	X11 / Wayland	PDFium	Build from source

ONE CODEBASE, NO COMPROMISES

Cross-platform does not have to mean lowest-common-denominator. AirPDF uses native file pickers, native window chrome, and platform-aware keyboard conventions. On macOS, Command replaces Control. On every platform, the page is the same.

The project is designed to be read as well as used. The core document service has no UI dependencies. The Avalonia layer only knows how to present pages and respond to input.

CHAPTER FOUR · FIND

Search should feel like *turning a page*, not filing a request.

Press **Ctrl+F** and the document becomes a conversation. Results appear as fragments, ordered by page, with the active match highlighted in warm amber. The rest of the document fades to the background.

AirPDF reads the PDF text layer with PdfPig, then maps each match back to the rendered page. That means highlights line up with the words you can see, even in multi-column layouts. It is a small piece of geometry that makes a large difference.

Feather-light

No background indexer, no database. Search starts when you ask and stops when you close the panel.

Page-aware

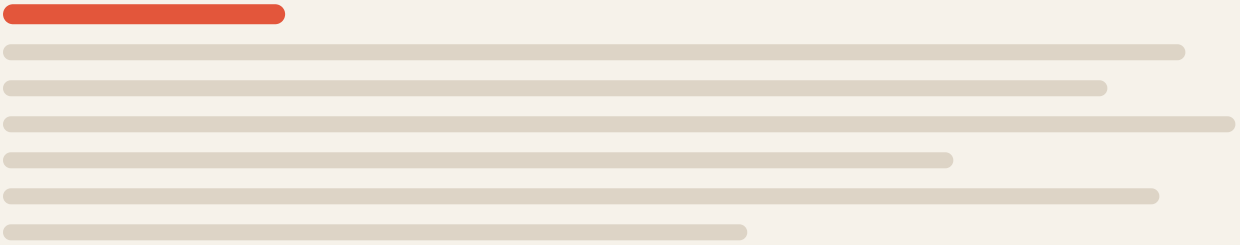
Matches are grouped by page, so you can move through a long report without losing your place.

Tip: press Enter to search, then use the arrows in the panel to move between matches. Escape returns you to the page.

CHAPTER FIVE · THE LONG READ

Built for the documents you keep.

A paper, a contract, a manual, a book you return to every winter. These are not disposable files, and the reader should not treat them that way.



The thumbnail rail is a map, not a menu. It stays out of the way until you need it, and it follows the page you are reading. The outline, when a document has one, is a single click away.

Zoom to fit width, fit page, or actual size. Move through pages with the arrow keys, or type a page number and press Enter. Every action is reversible, and nothing is hidden behind a paywall.

轻量，是一种阅读方式。

打开一份 PDF，不应该先经过登录、订阅和一连串弹窗。AirPDF 把页面放在最前面，其余的都退到背景里。

它使用 PDFium 渲染，使用 Avalonia 构建界面，在 Windows、macOS 和 Linux 上保持一致。没有云端，没有账号，也没有隐藏的付费功能。

阅读是一种安静的注意力。好的阅读器不会要求你注意它。缩略图、目录、搜索和缩放都在手边，但它们不会主动打断你。

这个项目会以开源的方式继续生长。代码、设计决策和路线图都会放在 GitHub 上，欢迎每一个愿意让阅读更轻的人参与。

0	3	1
账号	桌面平台	个页面

COLOPHON

Made to be opened again.

AirPDF is a small, open-source reader for the PDFs you actually live with. It is built in public, under the MIT license.

AirPDF 0.1

Field Notes, first edition · 2026
Set in Georgia and Segoe UI · Rendered with PDFium

This document is part of the AirPDF test suite. It contains searchable text, mixed typography, a Chinese-language page, and enough pages to exercise virtualized scrolling. The words “AirPDF”, “feather-light”, and “PDFium” appear throughout for search testing.